



LIFTOFF! More than two thousand tons of spacecraft and fuel head into space as space shuttle *Endeavour* thunders out of the launch pad in 2009 at the Kennedy Space Center in Florida. From 1982 to 2011, shuttles made more than 130 successful spaceflights.

Each of a shuttle's two large, solid rocket boosters holds 100,000 lb (450,000 kg) of fuel, which is used up in the first two minutes. The shuttle's main engines continue burning, using all of the 530,000 gal (two million liters) of fuel held in the 157-ft- (48-m-) long orange, external fuel tank by eight minutes after launch, when the shuttle is traveling more than 16,800 mph (27,000 km/h). This mission carried seven astronauts to the International Space Station, returning to Earth 17 days later.